India’s relations with Pakistan fared little better during this period. Efforts at reviving talks, including at a meeting of the Indian and Pakistani prime ministers at Sharm el-Sheikh in Egypt in 2009, were heavily criticized in India. [11] Although Prime Minister Manmohan Singh desired a visit to Pakistan, resistance within his own party prevented one from taking place. Despite attempts at insulating dialogue from terrorism, continuing terrorist attacks against civilian targets in India, domestic political tumult in Pakistan, and growing frustrations in New Delhi ensured that India–Pakistan relations remained in turmoil without resolution. [12]

Reengagement: India’s Neighbourhood, 2014–2019

An opening was created once again with the election of Narendra Modi as India’s prime minister on the back of a large parliamentary majority in 2014. Modi’s first act was one of foreign policy—inviting the leaders of Pakistan, Afghanistan, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, the Maldives, and Mauritius to his oath-taking ceremony. This proved a way to start a dialogue with his counterpart in Pakistan, while also emphasizing the importance of the neighbourhood to his foreign relations. Modi’s first bilateral overseas visits as prime minister were to Bhutan and Nepal. In Nepal’s case, no Indian prime minister had visited in twelve years. The symbolism of these developments was meant to signal the renewed attention that India would give to its near abroad. [13]

In practice, despite the strong signal of intent, India’s neighbourhood relations sometimes proved bumpy. Bhutan—a major recipient of Indian grant and military assistance—remained steadier, even as its polity and public space became increasingly democratized and its outlook more international. With Bangladesh, Modi had the political capital to implement what his predecessors could not: a major Land Boundary Agreement. With a historic visit in 2015, India and Bangladesh swapped islands of territory that had prevented their boundary from being settled. A year earlier, India and Bangladesh had resolved their maritime dispute, with India opting to abide by international arbitration in Bangladesh’s favour. [14] These